Sharpening the Vision—Joshua Project 2000[1]

By Luis Bush

The question by mid-decade became how to work together more effectively toward implementation of the overall vision in the final five years of the decade while counting on a growing global prayer initiative. The answer was by sharpening the vision of a church for every people by focusing on a selected list of 2000 least evangelized larger peoples of the world.

As the decade unfolded, two rather distinct phases of AD2000 emerged, with GCOWE '95 serving as the dividing line between the two phases. The first phase was the vision-sharing phase, the second the mobilization or implementation phase. In consultation with the AD2000 network and task force leaders, a document was prepared for national and regional leaders from 186 countries of the world called "Possible Outcomes of GCOWE '95 to Fulfill the Unfinished Task by December 31, 2000." The document was reviewed in a number of sessions at GCOWE '95. Out of the process of consultation, the fact was established that delegates had faith to believe that God would continue to perform miracles to open the hearts of the lost, if the body of Christ would rise to the challenge. The expected result was the establishment of a mission-minded church planting movement within every ethno-linguistic people by AD 2000. In addition, there was conviction that the turn of the millennium was a unique occasion to reemphasize the urgency of taking the gospel to the ends of the earth.

A proposal directed to AD2000 leaders emerged: to build the next five years of work on two specific efforts, the AD2000 National Initiatives and Joshua Project 2000. These would be empowered through the networks, task forces and ministries related to the movement. So Christian leaders from seventy-seven countries met in a seven-day conference, from November 28 to December 2, 1995, in Colorado Springs, called *The Launch*. Its purpose was to set in motion the five-year, final thrust of AD2000. The backbone would be National AD2000 Initiatives, along with a new project, Joshua Project 2000. Both thrusts would be empowered by the existing and new AD2000 resource networks and task forces. It was the conviction of participants that through Joshua Project 2000 the almost 2000 least evangelized larger peoples of the world would have a church planting movement initiated by the year 2000. The expectation was that through the AD2000 national initiatives, both the Joshua Project 2000 peoples and the unreached

[1]Bush, Luis K. (2001). *Catalysts of World Evangelization* (2002 Ph.D. Dissertation from SWM, Fuller Theological Seminary, Ed. 2006), Centre for Contemporary Christianity, Bangalore, India. Pages 141-144.

peoples less than 10,000 in number would have a church by the year 2000.

It was the conviction of participants at GCOWE '95 that a global effort was needed to focus attention and provide tools for implementing the vision for the church for every people by the year 2000 by developing a selected list of unreached peoples. *The Launch* represented the initiation of the implementation phase of AD2000 for the second half of the decade following the vision-casting phase of the first half. In order to work together toward the vision two approaches were adopted, (1) national initiatives to the year 2000 that would prioritize pioneer church planting among the unreached and, (2) Joshua Project 2000.

Joshua Project 2000 was a global cooperative strategy, focused on the least evangelized peoples of the world, which sought to engage every church, agency, denomination and Christian from every country in the world in an effort to implement the goal of "A Church for Every People and the Gospel for Every Person by AD2000." The goal of Joshua Project 2000 was to establish a pioneer church planting movement within every ethno-linguistic people of over 10,000 individuals within every country of the world by December 31, 2000. "The Joshua Project . . . is the largest strategic mobilization of Christians in history to disciple the people of the world. Support and enthusiasm have come from across a wide spectrum of denominations agencies and countries. In the latter, the involvement has been predominantly non-Western" (Johnstone 1998:107). To inform the vision of the 2000 largest least evangelized peoples an expansive research effort was conducted, and the information disseminated.